

Visual Wars

DX10 giving your ailing rig a hard time? Invest in one of these bad boys, and watch your games come to life and the frames blur...

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Promises are meant to be broken

They lied. NVIDIA and ATI lied to us. We were promised environment friendly GPUs. They also promised us silicon-conserving smaller die sizes and lower power requirements. We thought they were doing an *Intel* on us — add more cores while reducing power consumption. But they didn't. And, as shocking as this may seem, we're rather glad they chose to lie. Our GPUs can be as environment *unfriendly* as they like, we're not complaining! Sorry, Mother Nature, but *Crysis* comes first. If your parents read this placate them with the fact that an air conditioner left on for an extra hour, consumes around the same amount of power that the most powerful GPU does in two weeks. Not to mention the average hydrocarbon belching, public transport vehicle. So we find nothing to complain about

the power requirements of the new Radeon HD4870 X2 and the GTX 280. Except maybe, the cost of a GPU cooler and fan to prevent thermal meltdown. And the cost of a new, beefier power supply. And a new cabinet with better ventilation with maybe some 120mm fans. And a small hike in power bills. Wait! We weren't supposed to complain, because there isn't anything to grouse about. Or is there?

The fact is that DX10 is here, and whether you like it or not, Microsoft has doomed good old Windows XP to the annals of history next year by limiting support for it. So Vista is here to stay, and so is DX10, at least until DX10.1 or even DX11 make their way into our desktops. Vista has become better and faster, although it still has a fair bit of catching up to do with XP when it comes to device driver support and compatibility. For us, moving to Vista as a benchmarking standard was an easy choice, and it's been an enlightening experi-

ence. For one, we had none of the problems that people usually complain about — no crashes, no bugs, and the frame rates of all our games were on a par with the scores obtained while benchmarking the same configuration with Windows XP, meaning that the added operating system overhead was practically nil.

If you're a gamer, you should consider moving to Vista for good. Others would have already transitioned to this platform, but gamers tend to lag behind with the fear of Vista killing their GPUs. Well, it isn't Vista you should thank for that, it's a little setting in most games called *Ultra High*. This setting remains greyed out in Windows XP and cannot even be selected. But it is available when running Vista. What it does is enable DX10 effects. This is solely responsible for the large performance drop you experience when using Vista and enabling all the eye candy. And while on the subject of visual appeal Vista is more beautiful, noticeably so,

How We Tested

Test Configuration:

CPU - Intel Core 2 Extreme X6800 (2.93 GHz)

Motherboard - ASUS Rampage Extreme (Intel X48 Express Chipset)

RAM - 4 GB OCZ DDR3 1600 MHz

HDD - WD Raptor 80 GB (10,000 RPM, SATA)

OS - MS Vista Ultimate 64-bit

Monitor - Samsung SyncMaster 997DF

Below are the benchmarks we used, along with a brief description.

Crysis

The most feared game for its ability to kill even the most powerful cards. One of the best looking games ever built, with great shader quality and amazingly realistic environments and effects, as well as incredibly detailed characters and gameplay. Visually stunning.

Unreal Tournament 3

Using the next gen *Unreal Engine 3*, UT3 is a game not to be missed. Its faster than its predecessors, and visually splendid too.

S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Shadow of Chernobyl

The X-Ray engine by GSC gameworld - an open ended explorative

experience, this game has incredible detail, expansive maps and an eerie kind of ambience, especially when roaming its environs at night. The bleak, scarred landscape is brought to life with some beautifully done shaders and texturing. A superb looking game.

Company of Heroes: Opposing Fronts

One of the best looking RTS games, brilliant detail, and very realistic enemy AI. An absolute gem of a game with eye candy to kill for.

World In Conflict

Perhaps the only RTS game that is the equivalent of COH in terms of visual appeal, this one has large scale, highly detailed battles.

F.E.A.R. Perseus Mandate

Atmospheric, dark and gloomy and still unforgiving on older cards, F.E.A.R. is still the best in the business when it comes to close quarters firefights and scaring your lights out with some incredible visual effects. Great shadows, realistic combat, and very immersive.

3D Mark Vantage

Future Marks new 3D benchmarking standard, very taxing on older cards. Showcases DX10 shaders very well.